

The Redemption Cycle

The time of the Judges. Those days after Israel entered the land of Canaan with Joshua up until the day of Saul's anointing, or the days where Israel had no king.

If you've participated in any Bible studies focused on the book of Judges, you may remember one of the most common occurrences documented in its pages. Israel messes up, again, and again, and again. If you were to flip open your Bible and look for the phrase "The Israelites did evil in the eyes of the Lord," in some variation, you'd find it Judges 2:11, 3:7, 3:12, 4:1, 6:1, 10:6, 13:1—you get the picture. This doesn't include other ways that the Israelites "prostitute" themselves to foreign gods and other cultures, breaking the covenant they had made with God repeatedly; it's just a few of the token stories of Judges before Israel finally receives a king—and what a king they get. And as we study, we can't help but notice a cycle.

Rebellion
Bondage
Repentance
Deliverance
Peace

Repeat.

A cycle of Israel failing in their partnership and relationship. A narrative of mankind's sin and failure. A narrative of mankind continually falling short. This has to be the message behind the book of Judges, doesn't it? Or at least that seems to be the point based on how it has been taught to many of us.

The failures of Israel are there, no doubt about it; but is that the point of this part of the Story?

We can see the humanity in these people when we see their failures. They become more relatable to us, right? But what does that lesson, that conclusion, leave us with when we finish the book? When I read the book of Judges, I can't help but go back and ask myself a question we often discussed in Session 1: *What does this Story, the story of the failures, and few faithful judges, tell us about God?*

What does this story tell us about God?

In this God-focused, rather than a human/sin-focused light, *what might the message of Judges actually be?*

Now, we know God raised up judges to lead by example, hoping that each tribe of Israel would live up to their name, upholding their covenant to God. Some judges successfully led Israel for **40** years—thank you Deborah and Gideon. (And, yes, pay attention to those numbers.) Other judges led not quite so well—*cough* Japheth and Samson. (Any meaning behind the number of years of peace they had, I wonder?)

If we lean into your questions about these judges who served as good and bad examples, what do we learn? What do we find?

What you may find is endless patience and faithfulness on the part of God, and even those judges who seem to do their best to lead Israel in the right direction. Israel may, in between generations or years of flourishing, forget the covenant their people have with God, forgetting where they have come from.

**What you may find
is endless patience
and faithfulness on
behalf of God.**

But God is not one to forget or abandon His promises.

He promised He wouldn't, and has reminded His children repeatedly throughout the Story so far that He will not forget them or forsake them.

In fact, God does quite the opposite. He dies for them. Dies for us.

So in light of a different perspective, what does Judges show us about God? Should the cycle be focused on the failures and sins of mankind, or, rather, be a cycle of redemption—of forgiveness and patience and unending grace?

PRAYER

*Thank you for Your patience.
Thank you for Your goodness.
Thank you for Your faithfulness.
Thank you for Your unending, unfathomable love.*

Forgive me, forgive us, for when we fall short, and may our next step be to try and do the next right thing. May we remember the story isn't about our failures, but about You—Your willingness to redeem Your creation time and again.

Thank you for Your promises, and for grafting us all into Your Story. May we seek to be a part of this cycle of redemption, always.

Amen

THE FOUR PILLARS

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

Take time to review: dig into a part of the Text, Judges 6 maybe, and look for the characteristics of God versus Israel. What might the Text be showing us?



COMMUNITY

As a group, what cycle were you inclined to see before this episode and conversation? Do you see something different? How might this perspective shift your approach to the Text?



DISCIPLESHIP

Is there anyone you're taking with you into these new places? This book can be confusing or depressing—how might this new redemption cycle interpretation engage someone you know?



WRESTLING

What questions remain? Why does the cycle of Judges matter? What do you want to dig into more? What else might the original authors be trying to show us about God?



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Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 2



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases that we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE SPIRITUAL FORMATION

*True success is developing intimacy with God. In Session 1, we encountered the idea of “Creating Space for God” in our lives. We believe that **if we do our part of creating that space, God will fill it** as He desires. You’re already doing this as you dive into the Text and jump into a place to discuss. God will meet you in these places! Look for places the Holy Spirit can do work in and through you as you go about your everyday life.*

CONSIDERING CAMPUS YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS

***We believe that young adults are shaping the future of this world.** Jesus modeled a ministry of discipling young adults, and that approach has and will work. If you are a college student who is listening, we want this material to be directly helpful to your pursuits. If you are not a college student, we want to challenge you to come alongside one and work together.*

SACRED STATION THEOLOGY OF WORK

*This isn’t only for church or Bible study; this is about what we do every day. How we do our job and how it may take advantage of or bring life to others is something God says is central to our presence in the world. Justice is very much something God cares about. Does our physical work (our 9–5 job) bring shalom or chaos? Does it exploit creation? The way we manage our employees, interact with customers or coworkers, care for our children, or create products can provide relief to others. **The work we do every day is sacred and matters!***